opposition makes stick its charge that she's sold India's dignity for a mess of pottage."[123] Johnson, however, remained unmoved.

Rusk explained to Bowles that even beyond Johnson, India had been losing supporters in Washington because of its approach on Vietnam. The Gandhi-Nasser-Tito statement that fall did not help. Highlighting the critical congressional factor, he said, "While we must avoid the overt impression of political conditions, the truth is that India has a political constituency in the US which it must nourish if it expects substantial concessional help.… The gratuitous departure of India from a position of non-alignment in Viet-Nam does not help at all."[124]

By November, however, the situation in India had deteriorated. Freeman and Rusk joined Rostow in recommending the approval of at least a stopgap amount, while waiting to make a larger commitment until the US had a better sense of the status of Indian reforms.[125] Bowles argued that independent observers had already reported that India was performing better than ever. He also said that whatever their differences, "if we get into a war with China, India will, reluctantly to be sure, be dragged in on our side." Bowles simultaneously cautioned Rusk about the consequences of the even shorter American tether on Indian economic planning and the upcoming Indian election in 1967.[126]

Upset about the Gandhi-Nasser-Tito statement, Johnson, however, pointed out that India had not seemed to be concerned about "kicking us" before the US midterm election. He said he was going to take his time until the US Congress came on board. A study group subsequently reported positively on Indian performance. But Johnson stated that because of budget pressure, domestic needs, and the costs of Vietnam, he did not want to go further than one-quarter of what Freeman was recommending without Congressional buy-in.[127]

Indian policymakers were upset that Johnson kept moving the goal posts. Given the desperate situation, officials proposed purchasing grain from the US despite their constrained resources.[128] The Indian government was under attack at home, with even an establishment newspaper stating that "The Grimmest Situation in 19 Years" was the Congress Party's fault.[129] Perhaps to divert criticism from the government and pressure Johnson, in November, Gandhi publicly mentioned the delay in US shipments. Denying that India was undertaking insufficient reforms, she said the delay meant